



Leading a revolution: This was Sinner's fourth Grand Slam title and his second of the year, following his win at the Australian Open. GETTY IMAGES

JANNIK SINNER DETHRONES CARLOS ALCARAZ

Sometimes it takes a bit of good fortune to win Grand Slam titles, even for The Great Ones. Grigor Dimitrov, touted as 'Baby Fed' early in his career for his athletic and stylistic resemblance to superstar Roger Federer, was playing the match of his life in the fourth round against Jannik Sinner.

The 34-year-old Bulgarian, seeded No. 19, built a stunning 6-3, 7-5, 2-2 lead by attacking 29 per cent of the time (compared to 23 per cent for Sinner), hitting 36 winners, and taking 20 of 29 net points. Serving at 40-love, Dimitrov grabbed his right pectoral muscle during a routine backhand volley. Then at 40-all, he writhed in pain. He laughed and then cried at his cruel fate.

For the fifth Major in a row, the snake-bitten Dimitrov was forced to retire with a serious injury. Sinner would lose only one other set during The Championships, to Carlos Alcaraz.

About his unusual victory, Sinner rightly said, "I don't see this as a win." In fact, it took a toll on him, too. Jannik fell in the first game and landed on his elbow. Although it caused him pain, an MRI showed it wasn't serious. He wore a long protective sleeve covering taping on his serving arm against big-serving lefty Ben Shelton, the youngest American to reach the Wimbledon quarterfinals since Andy Roddick in 2004.

Shelton, seeded No. 10, certainly couldn't match Sinner's power, precision, and consistency from the baseline. But his improved volley helped him win 43 of 58 net points in his 3-6, 6-1, 7-6(1), 7-5 victory over Lorenzo Sonego. Shelton is coached by his father, Bryan, who made the fourth round here 31 years ago.

After losing his first match against Shelton at the 2023 Shanghai Masters, Sinner went on to win five straight matches, all in straight sets. This encounter would prove no different. Jannik looked sharp throughout, while Shelton was timid in the critical opening set tiebreak and succumbed 7-6(2), 6-4, 6-4.

Alcaraz, a happy warrior, started his title defence against the insouciant Fabio Fognini. The 38-year-old Italian had lost his last 10 Tour-level matches and was contesting his last Wimbledon in his farewell season. Returning Alcaraz's serve phenomenally and casually hitting groundstrokes on the rise, he gave the heavy favourite fits. Alcaraz pulled out an entertaining 7-5, 6-7(5), 7-5, 2-6, 6-1 victory, but his 35 forehand and 62 total unforced errors were a bad omen.

Alcaraz looked much sharper in his fourth-round 6-7(5), 6-3, 6-4, 6-4 win over 14th seed Andrey Rublev. The often-tempestuous 27-year-old Russian, who has been open about